Samuel Plach

Department of Social and Political Science, Bocconi University, 20136 Milan, Italy
Dondena Centre for Research on Social Dynamics and Public Policy, Bocconi University, 20136 Milan, Italy
samuel.plach@unibocconi.it | ORCID: 0000-0001-6819-9907 | Google Scholar | LinkedIn

Publications

- Plach, S., A. Aassve, L. Mencarini (2026, in Press). What is People's Ideal Number of Children and do They Achieve It? ***Demographic Research (DR)***
- Plach, S., A. Aassve (2026, in Press). Beyond Spending: Governance Quality and Citizens' Perceptions of Public Institutions as Drivers of Individual Resilience ***Journal of International and Comparative Social Policy (JICSP)***
- Plach, S., A. Aassve, N. Cavalli, M. Valetto (2026). Fertility Dynamics across High-Income Countries in a New Era of Polycrisis. ***Population and Development Review (PDR)***, 52: 872-907. doi.org/10.1111/padr.70091.
- Aassve, A., L. Mencarini, C. Peng, S. Plach, A. R. Amarales, M. L. Tanturri (2026). Parenthood Decisions in Uncertain Times: Experimental Evidence from Four Countries. ***Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences (PNAS)*** *123 (31) e2601690123*. doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2601690123.
- Aassve, A., A. Adserà, P. Y. Chang, L. Mencarini, H. Park, C. Peng, S. Plach, J. M. Raymo, S. Wang, J. Yeung Wei-Jun (2024). Family Ideals in an Era of Low Fertility. ***Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences (PNAS)*** 121 (6). doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2311847121.
- Plach, S., A. Aassve, N. Cavalli, L. Mencarini, S. Sanders (2023). COVID-19 policy interventions and fertility dynamics in the context of pre-pandemic welfare support. ***Population and Development Review (PDR)*** 50(S1): 363–393. doi.org/10.1111/padr.12557.
- Toffolutti, V., S. Plach, T. Maksimovic, G. Piccitto, M. Mascherini, L. Mencarini, A. Aassve (2022). The association between COVID-19 policy responses and mental well-being: Evidence from 28 European countries. ***Social Science & Medicine (SSM)*** p. 114906. doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2022.114906.
- Aassve, A., N. Cavalli, L. Mencarini, S. Plach, S. Sanders (2021). Early assessment of the relationship between the COVID-19 pandemic and births in high-income countries. ***Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences (PNAS)*** 118 (36). doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2105709118.
- Aassve, A., N. Cavalli, L. Mencarini, S. Plach, and M. Livi Bacci (2020). The COVID-19 pandemic and human fertility. ***Science*** 369 (6502), 370–371. doi.org/10.1126/science.abc9520.
- Research Assistance on: Corno, L., E. La Ferrara, A. Voena (2020). Female Genital Cutting and the Slave Trade. *CEPR Discussion Paper No. DP15577*.

Selected Works in Progress

- Plach, S., J. Garcia-Bernardo, B. Rosche, Z. Parolin. Social Networks and Intergenerational Mobility: Neighborhood and School Peer Effects.
- Plach, S., Z. Parolin. Social Capital, Automation, and Intergenerational Mobility.
- Garcia-Bernardo, J., E. Jaspers, W. Machado, S. Plach, E. J. van Leeuwen. Beyond Parents? Prediction Gaps in University Completion Using Population-Scale Networks and Flexible Machine Learning.
- Plach, S., M. Perotti, A. Aassve, L. Mencarini. Ideological Gender Differences and Partnership Formation.
- Park, H., N. Cavalli, S. Plach, S. Y. Yoon. When Childbearing Starts at Thirty: Korea at the Fertility Frontier.
- Plach, S., E. Latora, A. Aassve, L. Mencarini. How large is the Fertility Gap between People's Ideals and Realizations and What Explains it?
- Plach, S., E. Latora, A. Aassve, L. Mencarini. Fertility Ideals and the Fertility Gap across 86 Countries. The Role of Education.
- Latora, E., S. Plach, A. Aassve, L. Mencarini. Social Networks and the Gap between Fertility Ideals and Realizations.

Education

Bocconi University — *PhD in Social and Political Sciences* **Sep 2022 - expected Jun 2027**
Milan, Italy

- Focus: Socio-economic Mobility and Inequality, Social Network Analysis, Social Demography, Computational Methods in the Social Sciences
- Scholarship: Full Merit-Based PhD Fellowship

Bocconi University — *M.Sc. in Econonomics and Social Sciences (Final Grade: 109/110*)* **Sep 2017 - Apr 2020**
Milan, Italy

- Focus: Quantitative Methods (in particular Mathematics, Statistics, Microeconometrics), Applied Microeconometrics (Population Dynamics, Development Economics), Microeconomic Theory (Microeconomics, Social and Economic Network Analysis)
- PhD level course: Econometrics of Non-experimental Data (30/30)
- Master thesis: The Gender of Gender Equality and Fertility; Supervisor: A. Aassve (8/8)

University of Konstanz — *B.Sc. Economics and Business Sciences (GPA: 1.9†)* **Sep 2012 - Jul 2016**
Konstanz, Germany

- Focus: Quantitative Methods; Behavioral Economics; Psychology
- Bachelor thesis: Elections and Cooperation – An Experimental Study on the Behavioral Effects of Worker Participation

Professional Experience

Dondena Centre for Research on Soc. Dynamics and Publ. Policy, Bocconi Univ. — Res. Asst. **Feb 2026 - Nov 2026**
Milan, Italy

- Identities, Migration, Democracy (**We-ID**) Horizon Europe Project of A. Aassve: Cohesion through resilient democratic communities.

Dondena Centre for Research on Soc. Dynamics and Publ. Policy, Bocconi Univ. — Res. Asst. **Sep 2025 - Jan 2026**
Milan, Italy

- Towards a Resilient Future of Europe (**FutuRes**) European Research Executive Agency Horizon 2022 Project of A. Aassve: Resilience in ageing European societies.

Dondena Centre for Research on Soc. Dynamics and Publ. Policy, Bocconi Univ. — Res. Asst. **Dec 2023 - Dec 2025**
Milan, Italy

- Ageing well in an ageing society (**Age-It**) PNRR Next Generation EU Project of L. Mencarini: Political and social consequences of ageing in Italy and Europe (e.g. intergenerational conflict)

Dondena Centre for Research on Soc. Dynamics and Publ. Policy, Bocconi Univ. — Res. Asst. **Jun 2023 - Sep 2023**
Milan, Italy

- Towards a Resilient Future of Europe (**FutuRes**) European Research Executive Agency Horizon 2022 Project of A. Aassve: Resilience in ageing European societies.

Dondena Centre for Research on Soc. Dynamics and Publ. Policy, Bocconi Univ. — Res. Asst. **Jul 2020 - Aug 2022**
Milan, Italy

- Institutional Family Demography ERC Project (**IFAMID**) of A. Aassve: The role of culture and institutions in how global change affects socio-demographic behaviors

Laboratory for Effective Anti-poverty Policies (LEAP), Bocconi University — Research Assistant **Jun 2018 - Dec 2018**
Milan, Italy

- Design, analyze, and disseminate anti-poverty programs by using rigorous evaluation methods

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant: MSc. in Economics and Social Sciences, Bocconi University **2026/2027**
Milan, Italy

- Population Dynamics and Economics: Demographic change and economic and societal dynamics
  Focus: In-depth student supervision for final course research project.

Teaching Assistant: MSc. in Economics and Social Sciences, Bocconi University **2025/2026**
Milan, Italy

- Population Dynamics and Economics: Demographic change and economic and societal dynamics
  Focus: In-depth student supervision for final course research project.

Student Advising

Master Thesis supervison: MSc. in Economics and Social Sciences, Bocconi University **2025/2026**
Milan, Italy

- Elisa Latora (currently PhD student in Social and Political Sciences at Bocconi University): Social networks and the fertility gap. (First supervisor: A. Aassve)

Funded Research Projects

Social Networks and Intergenerational Mobility (SNetMob) – Bocconi University **Feb 2025 - currently**

- Focus: Using register data on the whole Dutch population to investigate the effects of social networks in neighborhood and schools on intergenerational mobility.
- Role: Co-PI.
- Collaborators: Javier Garcia-Bernardo (Utrecht Univ.); Zachary Parolin (Oxford Univ.); Arnstein Aassve (Bocconi Univ.); Ben Rosche (NYU Abu Dhabi)
- Funding (among other sources): Bocconi Senior Grant (SNetMob); 9.877 EUR; PI: A. Aassve.

Conferences & Referee Reports

Research Visits

- *Oxford Univ., Dep. of Social Policy and Intervention and Institute for New Economic Thinking (INET)* (Oct 6-Dec 5, 2026)
- *Utrecht Univ., Dep. of Methodology and Statistics (M&S) and ODISSEI Social Data Science Team (SoDa)* (Jun 8-14, 2026)
- *Utrecht Univ., Dep. of Methodology and Statistics (M&S) and ODISSEI Social Data Science Team (SoDa)* (Mar-Apr, 2026)
- *Korea University, Institute on Aging* (Seoul; Dec 15-17, 2025)
- *Utrecht Univ., Centre for Complex Systems Studies (CCSS) and Dep. of Methodology and Statistics (M&S)* (Nov-Dec, 2025)
- *Princeton University, Office of Population Research: Cross-National Family Ideals Working Group* (Apr 14-17, 2025)

Selected Conference Presentations

- *EPC (European Population Conference) 2026* (Bologna; Jun 3-6, 2026)
- *RC28 (Social Stratification) Spring Meeting 2026* (Sevilla; May 20-22, 2026)
- *Dondena Workshop on Population and Social Dynamics* (Milan; Dec 11, 2025)
- *PopDays 2026* (Cagliari; June 4-6, 2025)
- *PAA (Population Association of America) Annual Meeting 2025* (Washington DC; Apr 10-13, 2025)
- *RC28 (Social Stratification) Spring Meeting 2025* (Universitá Degli Studi Di Milano; Mar 25-27, 2025)
- *Post-Modern Ideals of Family? Results from Eight Low Fertility Countries* (Bocconi Univ. Milano; Dec 18-19, 2025)
- *EPC (European Population Conference) 2024* (Edinburgh; Jun 12-15, 2024)
- *Inaugural Dondena-Cornell Gathering (DOCG)* (Rocca Grimalda; Jun 9-12, 2024)

Selected Seminar Presentations

- *Young Complexity Researcher Lunch: Social Networks and Intergenerational Mobility* (CCSS, Utrecht Univ.; Dec 3, 2025)

Summer Schools

- Summer School on Socioeconomic Opportunity and Inequality at Bocconi University (29 Jun-3 Jul , 2026): Focus: Multidisciplinary underpinning for effective research on inequality dynamics.
- Networks -– An Interdisciplinary Perspective on Connectivity at University of Tuebingen (8-11 Oct, 2024): Focus: Complex networks – different areas and methods.
- ODISSEI-SICSS at Erasmus University Rotterdam (Jun 19 - Jul 1, 2023): Focus: computational social sciences; Focus: Research challenges on forecasting fertility through machine learning tools using panel and administrative data.

Selected Conference or Workshop Attendances

- *Inequality & The Future (Dondena Centre, Bocconi and Stone Center, Chicago University* (Jun 29-30, 2026)
- *Fertility Goals: Conceptualization, Measurement, and Impact for Science and Policy* (Apr 10, 2025)
- *1st Conference on European Polarisation (CIVICA)* (Feb 15, 2023)
- *Family Ideals in an International Comparative Perspective at Princeton University* (Oct 29-30, 2022)
- *NBER Summer Institute* (July 11-29, 2022; July 12-30, 2021; July 6-25, 2020)
- *MPIDR Conference on Covid-19 Pandemic and Its Impact on Fertility and Family Dynamics* (13-14 Dec, 2021)
- *IUSSP International Conference on Family and Fertility* (3-5 December 2020)
- *UN Population Div. Expert Group Meeting (EGM) on the Impact of the COVID-19 Pandemic on Fertility* (10-11 May, 2021)
- *Network Dynamics in the Social, Economic, and Financial Sciences* (Politecnico di Torino, 4-8 Nov, 2019)

Referee Peer Reviews

- Population and Development Review (17/08/2025)
- Social Indicators Research (11/01/2025 and 03/07/2025)
- Population Research and Policy Review (14/03/2023 and 01/08/2023)
- Journal of Women's Health (07/12/2020)

Software & Language Skills & Associations & Other Qualifications

Software

- Advanced: **Stata**, **R**, **LaTeX**, **MS Office**. Intermediate: **Python**, **Gephi** (Networks). Basic: **EViews**, **ArcGIS**.

Languages

- **German** (native speaker), **English** (fluent, TOEFL iBT score: 113/120), **Italian** (intermediate, B1), **French** (beginner)

Associations

- Former member of the Economic Society for Bocconi Students
- Former member of the Behavioral Insights Association (B.BIAS) for Bocconi Students

Other Qualifications

- Graduate Management Admission Test (GMAT): Total score 690/800 (86%)
- Online course by Matthew O. Jackson from Stanford University: *Social and Economic Networks: Models and Analysis*

*Bocconi grading system: GPA of 27.64 (min: 0; max: 30) scaled up to 110 grade points, plus 8 grade points (min: 0; max: 8) for the Master thesis.

†German grading system with 1.0 being the best grade and 5.0 the worst.